

a digital download for FREE. That's right. Windows 10 will not cost you a single rupee (unless you factor in the bandwidth cost of downloading a 3 GB file). Excited? Of course you are! Skeptical? Well you should be; especially since this is the same company that just a few years ago charged its users \$199 to upgrade to a Professional Edition of Windows 7.

Furthermore, Microsoft has stated that this version of Windows will be the "last". While it goes without saying that users will continue to receive updates for optimizations and bug fixes, the general interface and feature list may remain largely the same. To help alleviate your fears of upgrading to this latest and (in all probability) final retail version of Windows, we have taken the trouble of answering some common questions you might have before you click that "Upgrade Now" button.

Why has Microsoft taken such a philanthropic turn? Surely there must be some catch as to why this upgrade is "free".

Surprisingly, no. And for this, there are a number of reasons. According to some analysts, offering a free upgrade is bound to spur consumer adoption, which in turn will ultimately benefit Microsoft. Furthermore, the faster Windows 10 expands its active user base, the more non-Windows users will be encouraged to purchase a copy of Windows. Further, as more users shift to Windows 10, the number of Windows 7/8/8.1 users will gradually reduce. As a result, these versions will receive fewer updates as Microsoft shifts their focus to improving the overall user experience of Windows 10. This will eventually force users to upgrade their systems to an operating that will undoubtedly be better supported.

As we discussed in the first chapter from a fiscal point of view, the decision to allow existing users to upgrade for free might not hurt Microsoft as much as people think. Microsoft will still continue to make money from the sales of new PCs that will come preloaded with a copy of Windows 10. In fact, most home users will be running an OEM version of Windows 7/8/8.1, which unfortunately cannot be reinstalled on a new/upgraded system. In essence, OEM licenses are tied to the system/motherboard on which they are installed. So users buying an upgraded system with Windows 10 will invariably be paying for the new OEM copy they are receiving.

The tides of technology are slowly turning. The rise of the smartphone has seen users pining for an integrated ecosystem where they can get a unified experience across all their devices. Apple is trying to answer this